

Bahamas



Located off the Florida coast in the western Atlantic, the Bahamas comprises an archipelago of some 700 islands and 2400 cays, only around 30 of which are inhabited.



GEOGRAPHY

Long, mainly flat coral formations with a few low hills. Some islands have pine forests, lagoons, and mangrove swamps.



CLIMATE

Subtropical. Hot summers and mild winters. Heavy rainfall, especially in summer. Hurricanes can strike in July–December.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Over 60% of the population live on New Providence. Tourism employs over 40% of the labor force. There are marked wealth disparities, from urban professionals in the banking sector to traditional fishermen on outlying islands and illegal Haitian and Cuban immigrants. More women are now entering the professions. Government priorities are tackling narcotics trafficking and money laundering.



THE ECONOMY

Major tourist destination, especially for US visitors. Financial services: banking and insurance.



INSIGHT: The country's extensive merchant fleet consists mainly of "flag-of-convenience" vessels registered by foreign owners



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Commonwealth of the Bahamas

DATE OF FORMATION: 1973

CAPITAL: Nassau

POPULATION: 341,700

TOTAL AREA: 5382 sq. miles
(13,940 sq. km)

DENSITY: 88 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, English Creole, French Creole

RELIGIONS: Baptist 32%, other 29%, Anglican 20%, Roman Catholic 19%

ETHNIC MIX: Black African 85%, other 15%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Bahamian dollar = 100 cents